Lesson 6 — A Plan for Tuesday

Part 1 of 12: Passage — A Plan for Tuesday

Level: B1 (sixth step)

About 20 minutes · this part carries a sheet and audio

> How to do the listening. The same rule as every lesson so far: the student listens twice with no text, then reads. Audio files: `01-passage.mp3` first, then the other parts in order. Part `05-ll-and-gonna.mp3` is new — the short 'll and the weak going to.

1.1 Before listening (2 minutes, Arabic is fine here)

1. What are you going to do this evening, and what will you do if the power goes off?
2. Who decides the order of jobs when you work with other people?
3. What is the first thing you charge when the electricity comes on?

1.4 Now read the passage

Passage: A Plan for Tuesday (504 words)

There are four of them, and between them they have one inverter, one battery, two laptops and a list. The list is on the back of a door in a room at the college, and every Sunday evening they write next week's plan on it. The plan is not about the work. The plan is about the power. Everything else on the list follows from that.

[A] The electricity in their part of the city comes in two blocks, and the schedule changes every month. This month it is on from six in the morning until nine, and again from seven at night until eleven. Seven hours. Dalia, who keeps the list, says the first thing you learn is that seven hours is enough, if you decide what each hour is for before it starts.

So the list has two columns. On the left is what they are going to do while the power is on: plug in both laptops, charge the battery, download the week's lecture videos, and send the group project up to the cloud. On the right is what they will do when it goes off: read, write, plan, and argue about the design. Every line has a name beside it, so nobody is waiting for somebody else to begin.

[B] Yousef is in charge of the downloads. "I am going to start the big files at six," he said on Sunday, "and I'll leave the small ones until the end. If the bandwidth is bad, we will still have the lectures." He has learned not to queue everything at once. Last month he put eleven files in the queue at six o'clock and had four of them by nine.

Nour is going to finish the database work before Thursday, because the deadline is Thursday night and she is going to submit it on time this week. Hani is going to rebuild the spare laptop, the one with the broken socket, and he says it will be ready by Wednesday. Nobody believes him. He says that every week.

[C] There are rules on the list as well, and all of them are about priority. The battery is for the router first and the laptops second. Nothing that can be done on paper is done on a screen while the power is on. And whatever else happens, the project goes to the cloud before eleven, because a file that exists in one place does not really exist.

[D] Dalia will not say that the plan always works. Last Tuesday the generator in the building below them failed at half past seven, and the two blocks became one. They lost three hours. But they had sent the project up at seven, so they lost three hours of work and nothing else, which is the whole reason for the rule.

On Sunday she will write the next list, and it will look much like this one. "We are not going to get more hours," she says. "So we are going to get better at the hours we have."

1.5 Read aloud

Read the passage aloud once and record it. Watch the two short forms as you read: say I'll and /ˈgənə/, not I will and going to.